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Operation Urban Warrior

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Operation Urban Warrior was a [United States Marine Corps](#) program created as an exercise meant to plan and test Military Operations on Urbanized Terrain (MOUT) and [urban warfare](#) in general. It was developed in the mid-1990s by the [Marine Corps Warfighting Laboratory](#) partly in response to growing problem on inner-city fighting, and especially made urgent following the [Battle of Mogadishu](#) in 1993.

Press materials from the Warfighting Lab in 1997 stated, "...the world is becoming increasingly urbanized and increasingly dangerous" and described a new fight zone called the "urban littoral," or coastal zone where most of the world's population will reside. "Parts of the urban littoral will contain all the classic ingredients for conflict. There will be social, cultural, religious and tribal strife between different groups. Many areas will have scarce resources, including the most basic ones like food and shelter as populations grow and resources shrink even further. The chances for conflict will naturally grow with it".^[1]

Some preferred to call it the "Three Block War".^[2] The concern that Marines would be made responsible for humanitarian assistance, as evidenced by the Bosnian War, was part of the original planning of the program. According to a 1997 *Defense Monitor* brief, the Marines were facing the burden of excessive operational tempo related to humanitarian concerns. The importance of getting the military out of humanitarian relief was expressed in the 1997 Center for Defense Information brief.^[3]

Background [\[edit \]](#)

Our enemies, having watched [Desert Storm](#) on [CNN](#), know they cannot engage the United States with conventional methods. These potential foes view cities as a way to limit the technological advantages of our military. They know that cities, with their narrow streets, confusing layout and large number of civilian non-combatants, place limits on our technological superiority and especially our use of firepower. We have to develop technologies that allow us to win while minimizing collateral damage.

—Colonel Mark Thiffault, Director, Joint Information Bureau, Urban Warrior

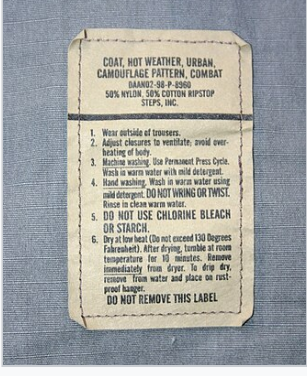
The program has been called one of the most important in the [United States Armed Forces](#).^[*by whom?*] This is because, even though the U.S. is believed to have one of the most powerful conventional military forces in the world, a number of the more powerful weapons systems intended for use fighting in open places are useless in urban settings. This was the case in some forested regions of Europe, and in open [deserts](#) encountered during the [Gulf War](#) and [Iraq War](#). Lines of approach through cities tend to be long and narrow, with sharp turns, civilians, street traffic and local commerce. This environment is one where heavy fighting vehicles like the [M1 Abrams](#) can not maneuver well, avoid being seen from a long distance by potential hostiles, nor be certain that all ground surfaces will support vehicle weight.^[*citation needed*]

Inhabitants may have any of a huge number of possible reactions, including anger, resentment, disrespect, and a strong potential for spontaneous protest, disorder, and uninitiated response.^[citation needed] Those who are friendly may be desperate for assistance but afraid, increasing the risk of stampedes and other problems. Those who are hostile will be on their home ground, have familiarity with the terrain, and decide to defend their home turf. Furthermore, those who use **unconventional warfare** will have found protection among inhabitants. To use options like **airstrikes**, **artillery**, and **mortars** against cities will have a high cost in missed targets and civilian casualties. History records multiple military operations involving cities, of which a large number degenerated into torturous situations with massive casualties. **Stalingrad** and **Saigon** are two modern examples.

As the world's population becomes concentrated in cities, current and future fighting will likely to take place within them.^[citation needed] This means that there will be an increase in the demand for **infantrymen**, because infantrymen are uniquely able to enter built-up areas, uproot and clear them, defend them, and even search the local residence. This is one reason why United States military leaders plans include the reasonable assumption that the infantryman's role in combat operations will increase rather than decrease in the coming years, such as the **Land Warrior** system.

Urban Warrior is seen as having one primary purpose: to fight enemies in urban environments; with a secondary purpose is to conduct and refine [disaster relief](#) and humanitarian assistance for use in the United States and abroad. Doing so supposedly involves gaining the support and trust of the local population by engaging in humanitarian efforts, a project the Marine Corps has more recently^[*when?*] sought to distance itself from.^[*citation needed*]

Some lessons learned from Urban Warrior were applied in the [2003 invasion of Iraq](#) and subsequent [occupation](#). Fighting in [Najaf](#) and [Fallujah](#) has once again made it clear that local [irregular forces](#) tend to have the [advantage of home territory](#) and plentiful local support.^[*citation needed*] Religion, ideology, and culture may also play in the local [insurgent](#)'s favor. [Non-combatants](#) often side with them because of nationalism, ethnic connections, general dislike or even hatred, of a foreign invading force. For example, this tendency became clear in [Mogadishu](#), [Somalia](#), when civilians chose to support the [Habar Gidir](#) (as opposed to [United Nations](#) and U.S. forces), and in Fallujah, where most of the remaining civilians decided the invasion forces were less favorable than the insurgent defenders.^[*citation needed*]


 Experimental T-pattern BDU jacket^[4] ^[*permanent dead link*]


Label of experimental T-pattern BDU jacket

An experimental urban camouflage [Battle Dress Uniform](#) was developed and used during the Urban Warrior exercises of 1999. The pattern, sometimes called T-pattern or T-block, consists of a medium gray, dark gray, and black color arranged in a geometric pattern, intended as a 'pattern breaker' to make Marine troops harder to locate when in such environments. Like all modern BDUs, it is made of a lightweight [rip-stop](#) material. The pattern was never officially adopted, and it has since been superseded by [MARPAT](#).

History ^[edit]

Exercises in Chicago, May 1998 ^[edit]

Eighty Marines from [1st Battalion, 8th Marines](#), stationed in [Marine Corps Base Camp Lejeune](#), toured [Chicago](#) to enhance knowledge of urban [infrastructure](#), such as a [gas plant](#), [water facility](#), tunnels, bridges, and [police](#) and [Fire stations](#).^[*citation needed*]

Exercises in the San Francisco East Bay, March 1999 ^[edit]


 Marines with [1st Battalion, 5th Marines](#) prone against a hill on 16 March 1999 at Naval Facility Oakknole, CA

A four-day military exercise was planned and executed in [Oakland, California](#) in March 1999. A combined force of 6,000 Marines and 700 sailors took control of the grounds and buildings of the defunct [Oak Knoll Naval Hospital](#) and invaded the defunct [Naval Air Station Alameda](#) on the second day as part of a national effort called Operation Sea Dragon.^[*citation needed*]



Wikimedia Commons has media related to ***Operation Urban Warrior***.

After original plans to use the [San Francisco Presidio](#) were rejected by the [National Park Service](#)^[5] based on the size of the spectacle and its inherent environmental damage, and a trial run at the [Naval Postgraduate School](#) beach in [Monterey, California](#),^[6]^[7] Oakland Mayor [Jerry Brown](#) and [Alameda](#) Mayor [Ralph Appezato](#) welcomed the Marines to use their cities as a [proving ground](#).^[8] The operations included multiple aviation assets, such as [AV-8B Harrier IIs](#), [CH-46 Sea Knights](#), [CH-53 Sea Stallions](#), [AH-1 SuperCobras](#), and [UH-1N Twin Hueys](#), as well as several [Landing Craft Air Cushion](#). Five Navy ships, including [USS *Hornet* \(CV-12\)](#) and [USS *Bonhomme Richard* \(LHD-6\)](#), were brought in and opened for public view during the operations.^[*citation needed*]

See also ^[edit]

	United States portal
	1990s portal

- [Jade Helm](#)
- [Low-intensity conflict](#)
- [Counter-insurgency](#)
- [Divide and rule](#)
- [Irregular warfare](#)
- [Urban warfare](#)
- [Fourth generation warfare](#)
- [Military operations other than war](#)
- [Hearts and Minds \(Vietnam War\)](#)
- [Hearts and minds \(Iraq\)](#)

References ^[edit]

1. ^ Marine Corps Warfighting Lab press release 17 October 1997
2. ^ *Navy Times* - MC edition, 27 October 1997
3. ^ DC -I.S.S.N. #0195 - 6450
4. ^ "Album Archive" [↗](#). *get.google.com*.
5. ^ "Operation Urban Warrior" [↗](#). *SFGate*. 9 February 1999.
6. ^ "National News Briefs; Protests Against Exercise By Military in California" [↗](#). *The New York Times*. Associated Press. 14 March 1999.
7. ^ Staggs, Bill (13 March 1999). "Mock Invasion Takes a Detour Above Sea Life" [↗](#). *The New York Times*.
8. ^ Lee, Henry K.; Hamburg, Laura; Writers, Chronicle Staff (16 March 1999). "War Games Come Ashore in East Bay / Chanting protesters greet Marines and helicopters" [↗](#). *SFGate*.

External links [[edit](#)]

- *Urban Warrior* [🔗](#), the movie

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Leadership	Secretary of the Navy · Under Secretary of the Na Commandant of the Marine Corps · Assistant Commandant of the Marine Corps · Sergeant Major of the Marine Corps · Military Secretary to the Commandant of the Mar Marine Corps four-star generals · Marine Corps th (1942–1959 · 2000–2009 · 2010–present)	
	US Congress	House Armed Services Commi (Seapower and Projection For · Senate Armed Services Com (Seapower subcommittee)
Major commands	Organization of the Marine Corps · Headquarters I Marine Forces Command (II Marine Expeditionary Marine Forces Pacific (I Marine Expeditionary For III Marine Expeditionary Force) · Marine Forces R Fleet Marine Force (Atlantic · Pacific) · Marine Corps Combat Development Command (Training & Education Command (TECOM) · United States Marine Corps Warfighting Laborator Marine Corps Systems Command	
Auxiliary	Marine Corps Cyber Auxiliary	
Structure	Marine air–ground task force · Bases · Battalions · Brigades · Divisions · MEF/Corps · Marine aviation Marine expeditionary unit · Marine Security Guard Special Operations (Marine Raiders · Marine Raid Recon (Force · Division)	
	Others: List of current formation types of the United States	
Personnel and training	Personnel	Rank insignia · MOS · Notable Ma Historical Marines · Marine Astron Criminal Investigation Division · Judge Advocate Division · Chaplain of the Marine Corps · Associated organizations
	Training	Recruit Training · School of Infant Officer Candidates School · The B Martial Arts Program
Uniforms and equipment	Uniforms · Awards · Badges · Weapons · Vehicles Individual equipment	
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